



SIPRA DAS

BREWING DISSENT: Das with his resignation papers outside Parliament hardcore businessman who was working with the Congress to fulfil his personal interests.

Son of former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Babu Banarsi Das, the former Rajya Sabha MP nursed the Lucknow constituency since his days as the mayor of the city in 1992 and always projected himself as a leader of the powerful Vaish (Bania) community by adding Gupta to his surname. With a degree in law, he was looked upon as a new-age politician in the party and was made the secretary of the parliamentary party in 2003 and

the election in-charge of Tamil Nadu and Pondicherry.

Although Das had been eyeing the Lucknow Lok Sabha seat for years, he had never been given a chance to fight an election against former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Though he had been close to the party high command, his prominence in the state irked the Congress partly because Rahul Gandhi has chosen Uttar Pradesh as his battle ground to prove his leadership qualities. In fact, his inclusion as the minister of state for steel in January 2006 had come as a surprise for a large number of Congressmen.

After quitting the Congress party, it seems Das may get what he desires by siding with BSP. He has already tuned himself to Mayawati's line by alleging that the Centre has been neglecting Uttar Pradesh by not providing it a special package worth Rs 80,000 crore despite repeated demands by the state Government. It is now for Mayawati to make use of this resourceful player in state politics as a tool to further erode the Congress votebank. Congress's loss is definitely BSP's gain.

by Farzand Ahmed

Heartland Revolt

With Akhilesh Das's resignation, the Congress is likely to face more trouble in a state that holds the key to the throne in Delhi

The Congress party has just been hit by a thunderstorm, yet again. After failing to improve its condition in the assembly polls and losing to Mayawati in the by-polls of Azamgarh and Khalilabad, the party has suffered another jolt in the form of Akhilesh Das, who resigned from the party membership as well as from the Rajya Sabha on May 6. A former mayor of Lucknow and a former Union minister, he says he was unhappy with the caucus surrounding party general secretary Rahul Gandhi, which, he says, "controls everything". Das, an ambitious leader, had once been a familiar face overshadowing "Yuvraj" Rahul whenever he visited Lucknow. "If the coterie is not happy, then Rahul Gandhi is not happy and you cannot approach him. He is only a general secretary of the Congress, but he is controlling the entire nation," he alleged.

However, the Congress begs to differ. Party sources say that his covert hobnobbing with Chief Minister Mayawati was the reason for his

ouster, though it is said that Das, one of the resourceful leaders with considerable following in Lucknow and some other Vaish-dominated urban areas, has been angry with the Congress leadership ever since he was unceremoniously dropped from the Union Council of Ministers. The party has, for now, dismissed his "out of frustration" resignation as inconsequential and has called him an "opportunist" with Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee chief Rita Bahuguna Joshi adding that Das has proved to be a

